

Cross Kirk,¹ Haroldswick, in the island of Unst, was a place of pilgrimage not much more than forty years ago.

Counting the number of sheep, of cattle, of horses, of fish, or of any of a man's chattels, whether animate or inanimate, has always been considered as productive of bad luck. There is also said to have been an idea prevalent at one time, that an outbreak of small-pox always followed the census being taken. The ravages of small-pox before inoculation was introduced were terrible, so much so, that it was known as the *mortal pox*. Fair Isle was once nearly depopulated, and in Foula in 1720 there were scarcely enough people left to bury the dead. Brand² was told that on every visitation a third of the population were swept away, and a Mr. Bruce of Urie,³ about the time inoculation was introduced, estimated the number at a sixth. To John Williamson, known as *Fohnny Notions*, a common fisherman of Hamna Voe, Northmaven, and who was probably the mechanical genius mentioned by Low,⁴ is due the credit of making inoculation general. He dried the matter in peat smoke, then buried it for seven or eight years covered with a layer of camphor. In applying it, he raised a little of the skin of the arm with a knife of his own make, and that so gently that no blood escaped. Under the skin thus raised he inserted a very small quantity of the matter, and, replacing the skin, covered it with a bit of cabbage-leaf. This was the whole of his treatment, as he administered no medicine. According to the Rev. Mr. Dishington, out of several thousand patients treated by Williamson, not one was lost, nor was there one case where infection did not show at the usual time. Edmondston,⁵ himself, as has been before said, a medical practitioner, remarks on Williamson's treatment: "The most extraordinary part of the proceeding is, the purification of the matter, which, under his management, seems to resist the influence of

¹ *Second Statistical Account, Shetland*, p. 40.

² Brand's *Orkney and Zetland*, p. 72.

³ Low's *Tour*, p. 175.

⁴ *Ibidem*, p. 141.

⁵ Edmondston's *Zetland Islands*, vol. ii. p. 89.

powers which destroy the very contagion itself. Had every practitioner been as uniformly successful as he was, the small-pox might have been banished from the face of the earth, without injuring the system, or leaving any doubt as to the fact." Vaccination was introduced in 1804, and to the credit of the Shetlanders, almost at once, became general.

In Unst, when Low¹ wrote, on a funeral procession passing, the by-standers threw three clods one by one after the corpse. Can this have been a survival from Roman Catholic days of throwing earth on the coffin at the conclusion of the service? In Aithsting at the same date people would neither eat nor drink on Sunday till after service.² At the present day, when the coffin is brought out of the house in country districts, it is, previously to being lashed on to the spokes or bearer, laid on chairs or some other things for the lashing to be done, and, as soon as the procession moves off, the chairs, or whatever else the coffin has been laid on, are *carefully* upset, as otherwise there will be another death in the house within a week.³

Another⁴ curious funeral custom was, and perhaps still is, in vogue. The moment the funeral procession had started, the straw on which the corpse had been laid was burnt, and the ashes narrowly examined, to see if any footmarks could be seen amongst them. If any were found, they were supposed to be those of the next person who would die in the house.

As in other parts, in former days, a funeral was more a merry-making, after a douce, unsobber fashion, than a grave, solemn, affecting ceremony, and the kirks were as often as not used as the places in which to consume "the funeral baked meats." The writer was told by a minister of a ludicrous case of haggling, as to the amount of whisky necessary at a funeral, when at last the matter was clenched by the emphatic assertion—"Deil a bane o' her gangs ow'r Sandness Hill under four gallons."

¹ Low's *Tour*, p. 162.

² *Ibidem*, p. 81.

³ See Gregor's *Folk Lore*, p. 212.

⁴ *Second Statistical Account, Shetland*, p. 141.